

Chapter Seven

TOWARD A PHILOSOPHY OF THE SOCIAL – PART ONE: DURKHEIM, MARX, WEBER (AND SIMMEL) REVISITED

With regard to what I have termed a “philosophy of the social”, the earlier substantive chapters on Durkheim, Marx and Weber were presented as offering two contributions to such an endeavour. Firstly, they indicated the extent to which philosophical questions about society, sociality and the social have long been an aspect of social theory, even if this has been overlooked at points. Secondly, the analyses that were developed were envisaged as an example of how it is possible to think philosophically about the social. A further important claim that I have tried to make throughout this book is that battles over the concept of the social are not over, or should not be over. We need to be involved in contesting and developing some of our most basic concepts. The final chapter will, using the work of A. N. Whitehead, attempt to trace a philosophy of the social which recognizes but goes beyond the issues and ideas that troubled Durkheim, Marx and Weber. In order to allow for this, it is worth revisiting the discussions of these three writers as whole. This will enable a cross-comparison of their work and, more importantly, will indicate the elements which are still relevant today and which could be taken up by such a philosophy.

Durkheim

In Chapter Two, I argued that the social really was a problem for Durkheim. Indeed, *The Division of Labour in Society* can be read as his attempt to formulate exactly what constitutes sociality. The English title of this book is perhaps misleading as it mentions society, and suggests that Durkheim is interested in how the division of labour operates within this. The French title is *De la division du travail social*. There is no mention of society and it seems clearer that Durkheim’s main concern is what might be called the “division of social labour”.

Too often, Durkheim is taken as simply providing an account of how societies “hold together”, and that he believes that this occurs in terms of some kind of cohesion. This is taken as being in opposition to Marx who, it is claimed, views society as essentially riven or defined by conflict between classes. There are, indeed, elements of these ideas in the works of Durkheim and Marx but such readings of their work already assume that they, and we, know what society is. It is simply a matter of deciding whether this society is to be defined in terms of consensus or conflict. This misses an important point, namely, that Durkheim and Marx were less clear on the concept of society than is often thought. They approached the question the other way around, and attempted to identify the fundamental characteristics of sociality. They confronted, head-on, what I have called the “problem of the social” and, in their confrontations, they also engaged in what I have termed a “philosophy of the social”.

To return to Durkheim, in *The Division of Labour*, his main interest is what it is that constitutes “solidarity” or, to be more precise, what makes us “solidary” (*solidaire*). It is in this respect that I feel it is possible to talk of the problem of the social for Durkheim. Even though he only uses the phrase “the social” once (and not at all in this text), sociality, in terms of what makes us solidary, is the focus of this work. His argument rests on positing two different forms of being solidary: “mechanical” and “organic”. The key differences between these are established through the development of a more complex division of labour. According to Parsons (1968a, 323), this means that Durkheim resorts to a factor which is not social to explain the social. That is, a more complex division of labour developed as a result of an increase in population size. This is a biological factor not a social one. However, Parsons misses the more interesting implication of his criticism, one which was made central to my earlier discussions, namely, that “the social is natural”. Parsons has relied on a specific understanding of an irreconcilable split between the social and the natural. This is a trope which has infected much sociological thinking of the twentieth century. It is not, however, a split which is to be found in Durkheim. He takes the more interesting position of explaining how sociality comes about within nature; it is an aspect of the natural world.

That the social is natural is a crucial element of Durkheim’s sociology. If the social “world” were not a part of nature then it would be impossible to treat it scientifically. If the social world were divorced from nature, if it had its own forms of cause and effect, if it *only* displayed properties which were found nowhere else in existence, then there would be no way to ground these causes or properties in the same reality which is considered the province of the natural sciences. Durkheim’s claim that sociologists should put themselves in the same frame of mind as scientists would have no purchase, for the claims

of sociologists could not be compared with those of natural scientists as sociologists and scientists would be talking of completely different worlds. This is not to say that the social realm does not exhibit specific properties which are to be found nowhere else in nature. If this were the case then there would be nothing particular or specific about sociology which would enable it to be considered a specific field of research, analysis and knowledge. At the same time, these properties cannot be dislocated completely from nature, considered as a wider realm of existence. The specificity of sociology comes from the fact that it discovers and abstracts out one aspect of nature, just as biology, physics and chemistry do. This is why, throughout his work, Durkheim points to the “natural” status of phenomena such as “the division of labour” which is also to be found in animal groups; furthermore, that the different ways in which molecules and organisms associate grants them specific properties, and that the same applies to social groups. Association is natural; what is of interest is the manner of association.

This manner of association is closely tied to Durkheim’s concept of “sociability”. It might seem that this is an innate characteristic of humans, but this would be too simple an answer for Durkheim. It would undermine his bold attempts to account for the genesis of sociality and the foundation of the social. Durkheim has little truck with any concept of human nature and he certainly does not posit sociability as one of its unexplained features. Sociability is not a “thing”, it is a way of associating: “sociability *per se* is met with nowhere. What exists and what is really alive are the special forms of solidarity” (*DL*, 27). Sociability is, therefore, natural, in that it refers to specific forms of association (which are themselves natural). Sociability is not, however, a biological trait. Humans are not innately sociable. “It has not even been proved at all that the tendency to sociability was originally a congenital instinct of the human race. It is much more natural to see in it a product of social life which has slowly become organised in us, because it is an observable fact that animals are sociable” (*RSM*, 132). Animals can be sociable. Humans did not have to be. They have the capacity to associate in specific ways; they have the ability to be social. This is the core meaning of sociability – “sociability”. The problem that Durkheim faces here is that his argument appears to be circular. What produces sociability is “social life”. But he has not really explained what social life is, as yet. In order to do this, and to explain what is “social” about the social, what is specific about the arena which is the locus of the study of sociology, Durkheim ultimately locates this in morality.

The Division of Labour starts with the question of morality, not sociality. Notably, the first edition of *The Division of Labour* started with a much longer discussion of morality which is relegated to an appendix in later editions. It could be claimed that this might make Durkheim into more of an eighteenth-century thinker

than is often supposed. It brings him closer to the kind of concerns laid out by David Hume and, more importantly, Adam Smith who wrote a treatise called *The Theory of Moral Sentiments* (1759) which predates *The Wealth of Nations* (1776) but can be considered the philosophical basis of the latter, in that it attempts to ground the operations of the economic in a more general theory of human nature. Intriguingly, this makes it possible to argue that, for both Adam Smith and Durkheim, the moral is natural.

Of course, Durkheim takes a very distinct line, one which differs greatly from Adam Smith. The task for Durkheim is to move from morality to sociality. He thinks that he finds the means to do this in the fact that morality operates as a form of constraint. Again, such constraint is not, as yet, limited to the social realm. Constraint is natural: “this force is a natural one” (*RSM*, 143). In the other areas of nature, such constraint is usually physical. Gravity is a constraint on objects, for example. What is specific about the form of constraint which operates in the social arena is that it is moral: “Man’s [*sic*] characteristic privilege is that the bond he [*sic*] accepts is not physical but moral” (*S*, 252). This might seem to make sense but it is only one stage in Durkheim’s argument, though an important one. For what constitutes the specificity of moral constraint? The answer to this question is that morality gains its authority, and hence its ability to constrain, from collectivity.

Collectivity is a key concept which runs throughout Durkheim’s texts, albeit in different forms and in different ways. In *The Division of Labour*, Durkheim outlines the different forms of collectivity which make up mechanical and organic solidarity. In *Suicide*, he traces how supposedly individual acts of suicide are only understandable and explainable in terms of their being informed by wider “social” operations. However, it is only really in *The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life* that Durkheim finally turns to a sustained investigation of collectivity. The early sections of this book talk extensively of “collective representations” but towards the end of the text he develops his most philosophical discussion of the character of collectivity, when Durkheim introduces his concept of “collective thought”. This is an important and interesting point and one which absolves him of many of the charges of social construction that have been laid at his door. For he insists that just because forms of collective thought come about at a certain point in time, this does not make them mere “social inventions”. Collective thought expresses something which is in nature, which is natural, which can have effects. Durkheim remains faithful to his claim that the social is natural.

Having said this, I am not sure that Durkheim’s late considerations of collective thought are enough to shore up the extent to which collectivity operates throughout his earlier texts where he uses this notion, in different guises, to support some of his most basic contentions. For example, sociality,

sociability, solidarity, the social, all derive ultimately from the specific kind of authority which is inherent in the collectivity of morality. This is why in all his primary examples of the operations of sociality, Durkheim resorts to examples of a collective moral response, in terms of a negative reaction; that is, through the punishment of a contravention of this collective morality. In an important sense, Durkheim derives his sociology from criminology, not the other way around, as criminology is concerned, in Durkheim's eyes, with identifying, initially at least, the different forms of punishment which accompany instances of going against a collective morality. However, Durkheim seemed to become aware that his argument had not been fully made and that he needed to return to this question of collectivity in *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life*. But he did so in a way which does not support or justify his earlier discussions of the collectivity of morality which was his supposed basis of sociality, of the social. The problem remains: Durkheim's approach to the social requires collectivity in order to get off the ground. If there is not an identifiable collective, then there is no social. It is not possible to have a piecemeal approach, to claim to find quasi-collectives. The authority and power of society and the social *must* come from the collective, according to Durkheim. Yet, what constitutes such a collective is not as simple to explain or define as might first be thought.

Nevertheless, there is a restless honesty in Durkheim, as he seeks repeatedly to ground and explain sociality (and thereby the legitimacy of sociology). However, in the end, he seemed unable to adequately describe exactly what is social about the social. Also, he never developed a coherent concept of society. Was it simply the nation state? If so, what are we to make of his discussions of partial societies (the domestic, the political, etc.)? And his occasional references to European society? This wariness, if not confusion, as to the status of society is evident not just in the work of Durkheim but also that of Marx and Weber. The role of the concept of society is not something that we should take for granted in any of their writings.

In conclusion, Durkheim should be approached with caution but also with admiration. We should be cautious in assuming that we can take from him any simple notion of sociality. We should, perhaps, interrogate our own understanding and usage of phrases such as "social conditions" and "social factors" to see how much they rely on an unfounded Durkheimian conception. But we can also admire the relentless manner in which Durkheim struggled in his attempts to account for sociality. He returns again and again to what I have called the problem of the social and in doing so, especially in *The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life*, he develops a philosophy of the social. For him, these questions were not settled, they were very much alive and required more work, more discussion, more debate. This lack of assurance in Durkheim's work with regard to the social

is something that we have lost, and this runs the danger of letting commonplace, unconsidered, conceptions run unchecked within social theory.

Marx

Marx rarely talked positively about the abstract character of society. He did not provide a definition of what he understood society or societies to be. This fits with his overall theoretical (and practical) approach, namely, that to talk of society in abstraction is mistaken. There are only ever real societies, with their own characteristics and their own reasons. This does not mean that we cannot glean something from Marx's writings with regard to his views on society. One important text in this regard is his *Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right*. This involves an immanent critique of Hegel's attempt to trace the supposed actualization of the progress of reason in the development of the early nineteenth-century Prussian state. This critique includes a refusal, on the part of Marx, to take as self-evident the concept of civil society, which is the mainstay of Hegel's argument and which seems to refer to the same "thing" as that which Adam Ferguson and Adam Smith had previously discussed. In his refusal, Marx evokes the German word "*Sozietät*" as opposed to the more common term for society, namely "*Gesellschaft*". This was not because Marx felt that "*Sozietät*", with its connotations of local, personal relations, was a better description of how society was or how society should be, as opposed to Hegel's grandiose, abstract account of regimented, nationwide, governmental edifices. Marx was trying to historicize Hegel's concept of civil society, not develop his own vision of society. Following Karsenti (2013), this points to the role of philosophy and social theory as a form of resistance. It is important to interrogate the conceptual stanchions upon which apparently innocent terms such as "civil society" seem to rest. This also highlights the active element of Marx's thought. The concept of society (and of the social) were not settled or agreed upon; they were still in the process of being made. Social theory should be part of this active making and should not reduce "society" and "social" to commonplace terms which we all think we understand. This is a line of argument that runs throughout Marx's texts. One key element of this is his choice to deploy two different adjectives when discussing "the" social. The adjective "*sozial*", which clearly bears some relation to "*Sozietät*" is always in tension with another adjective that Marx uses more frequently, namely "*gesellschaftlich*".

Marx never fully defines either of these terms. He was not a professional sociologist like Durkheim, and his concern was not to outline a theory of sociality, as such. This is why it is dangerous to read Marx's and Durkheim's discussions of sociality as if they were talking of the same "thing". It is vital to realize that the texts and concepts of Marx and Durkheim cannot simply be

read as different contributions to the same endeavour. This is to read history backwards, from a position where we think we know what we mean, now that the struggles for definitions are over. Instead, we need to pay attention to exactly what Marx and Durkheim were trying to construct.

Therefore, I suggest that a fuller understanding of Marx's position can be gained by translating "*gesellschaftlich*-" as "societal" and using "social" to translate "*sozial*". The reason for this is that Marx retains both of these terms from his earliest texts right through to *Capital*, sometimes using them in the same sentence, and he did this for a purpose. "Societal" indicates the specificity of a situation. "Social" refers to the elements of prestige or esteem which are associated with such societal forms but are not reducible to them. This means that contemporary society is not simply capitalist. Capitalist relations may be the preponderant societal relations but there are always other "social" relations which both reinforce and inhibit such relations. The most important point is that there is a tension between the two. Nothing is settled. The battle for the social and the societal continues. This is why the social constitutes a problem for Marx. Because it is not yet decided what form it takes. The arguments are not yet over.

Having previously said that Marx does not provide clear definitions of either the social or the societal, he does come close, with regard to the latter, in *The German Ideology* where he talks of "social [*gesellschaftlich*]" in the sense that it denotes the co-operation of several individuals, no matter under what conditions, in what manner and to what end" (*CWME* 5, 43; *MEW* 3, 30). There is always a manner, a mode, in which cooperation occurs. It is not that society is a fixed object; there is no such "thing" as capitalism. It gains its strength and its existence through the extent to which it informs ways of doing things. The importance of the differing manners of association for making a society what it is, is something that Durkheim also insists upon. "It is indeed certain that in the living cell there are only molecules of crude matter. But they are in association, and it is this association which is the cause of the new phenomena which characterise life" (*RSM*, 128). Marx would seem to agree:

To borrow an illustration from chemistry, butyric acid is a different substance from propyl formate. Yet both are made up of the same chemical substances, carbon (C), hydrogen (H) and oxygen (O). Moreover, these substances are combined together in the same proportions in each case, namely $C_4H_8O_2$. If now we equate butyric acid to propyl formate, then, in the first place, propyl formate would be, in this relation, merely a form of existence of $C_4H_8O_2$; and in the second place, we should be stating that butyric acid also consists of $C_4H_8O_2$. Therefore, by thus equating the two substances, expression would be given to their chemical composition, while their different physical forms would be neglected. (*CWME* 35, 33)

We should be careful with our abstractions. Just because something is made up of the same chemical substance does not make it the same thing. Diamonds, graphite, coal and grapheme are all made of carbon. It is the manner of their association which grants them their specificity and makes them what they are. It is perfectly possible to say that they are all carbon but this runs the risk of equating them all and selling a diamond for the price of a small piece of coal. The same applies to analyses of the social. We could say that societies are just all made up of people and that they differ over time and from place to place, but underneath it all they are the same, and they are all, in some ill-defined way, social. Such a view misses out exactly what is of interest, the manner of the association which makes people what they are, here and now. The social is not something which hides behind these processes. The social is expressed in the manner in which these processes occur. This is a point that Marx and Durkheim agree upon. And, it is notable that in his later texts, Marx refers less and less to society (“*Gesellschaft*”) and relies more and more upon adjectival forms (“*gesellschaftlich*-”) and nouns derived from verbs which express movement and processes (for example, “*Gesellschaftsformation*”).

Both Marx and Durkheim would seem to agree that what is required of sociologists and social theorists is not to accept society or the social as givens. We need to continually refine our conceptual approaches in order to better describe what we are now, and what, perhaps, we could be. To conclude on Marx, we might not be sure quite what he meant by society or the social, but he makes it clear that the battle to understand both and to act within both is on-going.

Weber

If Durkheim and Marx were less clear on their delineations of the social than is often thought, the same does not apply to Weber. In his later work he provided a very detailed and precise account of what he considered sociality to be. However, this precision seems to have often been missed. Another element of Weber’s thought which has not received much attention and which could provide a new slant on his outlook is that he had no real concept of society, in terms of “*Gesellschaft*”; in fact, it is not clear that he felt this to be a useful term at all. This might come as a surprise given that his last major work was titled *Economy and Society* (*Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*). However, this title was chosen by the editors of this work, which was published after Weber’s death, and the prominence of Society (*Gesellschaft*) in the title does not reflect the substantive concerns of what is to be found within.

Another important point is that, unlike Durkheim and Marx, Weber did seem concerned with outlining a very precise notion of the social. This concern became most evident at the end of his life; previously he used different, more generally accepted, terms although he was always aware that the concept of the social was a problematic one.

It is now no accident that the term “social” [*des Sozialen*] which seems to have a quite general meaning, turns out to have, as soon as one carefully examines its application, a particular specifically colored though often indefinite meaning. Its “generality” rests on nothing but its ambiguity. (Weber 1949 [1904], 68; 2012 [1922], 166)

Again, this provides evidence that Weber did not see the question of what constituted the social as settled. It was something that had to be fought for and clarified. What is notable with regard to Weber’s late adoption of a precise scheme for accounting for the social is the level of restraint that he insists upon when using this term. In the early sections of *Economy and Society*, where he outlines his concept of “social action”, Weber refuses to adopt the widely prevalent terms “*Gesellschaft*” or “*gesellschaftlich*” as fundamental. Instead, he describes the term social as “*sozial*”. As has been seen, this is a term that Marx also uses but Weber wants to develop a wholly different account. For Weber, the social only operates through three key concepts: “social action”, “social relationships” and “social selection”. Apart from these, Weber hardly ever uses the term social as a qualifying adjective. We do not find him talking, freely, of “social conditions”, “social factors”, “social existence”, for example. To do so would be to dilute his concept of the social as “*sozial*”; it would undermine the purpose and purchase of his argument.

“Social action” is not simply the meaning that an individual applies to their own behaviour and social action is certainly not simply “subjective”. These are certainly key aspects but they are not enough, by themselves, to make an action social. “Subjective attitudes” is the English translation of “*inneres Sichverhalten*”, which could be read as “inner relation to oneself”. What is crucial is that this inner relation is oriented to the behaviour of others, considered as comprised of similar such inner relations. Sociology and the social are founded on the existence of inter-relations which make up a form of interaction.

But there is more to Weber’s concept of the social than this. A second important step is that of “social relationships”. Such social relationships are not social relations in either Durkheim or Marx’s sense. Weber again chooses a different German word to that used by Marx who talked of relations as “*Verhältnisse*”. Weber prefers the word “*Beziehungen*”. Marx’s concept refers to wider, more general, relations. Weber’s term focusses on the one-to-one

aspect. It is much more of a relationship than a relation. The sharing of these relationships between a number of people, who therefore make up some kind of a group, is what constitutes genuine sociality, according to Weber. There are two main forms of such groupings of relationships: “*Vergemeinschaftung*” and “*Vergesellschaftung*”. Neither of these are simple static groups. Weber (borrowing from Simmel) makes a noun out of the process of becoming a group (this is the role of the prefix “*Ver-*”). The social does not subtend these groupings, it comes about through them. And they certainly do not rely upon or create any notion of a society considered as some kind of a totality.

That which makes such groupings social is not simply that they share something in common. There is a difference between something being held in common and being a genuine (social) community. For example, sharing a common language does not, in and of itself, make a community. For a community to be truly social, for example with regard to language, it is necessary that the individual members of that group actively recognize and act in a way which incorporates a conscious realization that this sharing of a language is a common feature of the members of this group and makes them different from other individuals who do not share this language. In the UK today, it is certainly not possible to hold that a common language somehow defines a shared society (as not all people in the UK speak English). Weber would also argue that the fact that there is a specific number of people in the UK who do have English as a first language does not make them a social group. It is only if specific members of that society actively share this feeling, and this influences their behaviour in relation to that of others, that they could be said to constitute a genuinely social, communal group. Any such general notion of society is not workable or useful, according to Weber. There is no society or social realm hiding behind our actions. There are not collectivities such as the State or the institution of education where the social lingers. The social is a precise, temporary, set of conscious interrelations. No more, no less.

Weber is adamant that both sociology and social action have very precise and delimited meanings and spheres of operation. At points he does suggest that there might be more to sociology than simply social action but, in so far as sociology is to be considered a science (*Wissenschaft*), it is only possible if a strict and narrow conception of the social is accepted as its basis. Surprisingly, perhaps, this does not preclude the possibility of animals engaging in some kinds of social action. The social is certainly not the privilege of human actors alone. Yet, the hallmark of Weber’s advocacy of the social is a level of precision which is often lacking in the texts of Durkheim and Marx. But this precision has a cost. If we are to follow Weber, it is not possible to liberally employ the term “social”, to apply to various phenomena, without following the strictures of his concept. The very fact that Weber only came to this position at the end

of his life (1919–20), shows that the battle for deciding what constitutes the social was very much still alive.

Simmel

It might seem strange that the work of Simmel is only being introduced right at the end. As I discussed in Chapter One, the main reason for this is that the texts and concepts of Simmel have not suffused the thoughts of social theorists and sociologists in the twentieth century in the same way that those of Durkheim, Marx and Weber did. Perhaps this is changing in the twenty-first century with a rebirth of interest in Simmel's works. It seems clear from recent treatments of his work (for example, Pyyhtinen 2010) that Simmel offers some important philosophical insights into the status and problem of the social. What follows is not intended as a full analysis of Simmel's position. I have chosen to address those aspects of his thought which relate to Durkheim, Marx and Weber, especially those which indicate the importance of developing a philosophy of the social.

Although Elliott and Turner (2012, 104) seem to suggest that Simmel uses the term “the social” (*das Sozial*) as a stand-alone noun, it does not seem that this is actually the case. However, Simmel does use the word “social” quite liberally. For example, in one paragraph he uses “*sozial*” to refer to “social individuals”, “social activity”, “social relations” and “social life” (Simmel 1971, 14; 1908, 26). Having said this, it is certainly possible (as is the case with Durkheim, Marx and Weber) to read a concept of the social into Simmel's texts. Perhaps the most striking element of this is the extent to which Simmel often starts such accounts by problematizing, if not denying, the existence of society itself.

Indeed, Simmel makes it clear that “Society” “is an abstraction [...] it is no real *object*. It does not exist outside and in addition to the individuals and the processes among them” (Simmel 1950, 4. Emphasis in original). Society is not an object, a thing; it has no substantive base. Instead, it is an outcome of the processes in which individuals engage. However, to say that Simmel had no concept of society would be too strong. His point is aimed at those, such as Durkheim, who want to found the social in some kind of pre-existing (collective) whole. For Simmel, the point is not to start with society but to end with it. Taken in this way, Pyyhtinen maintains that Simmel has two senses of society; one of which is broad, the other being narrow: “the first designates a specific socio-historical social order; the latter can be interpreted as a *principle of association*: it is coextensive with relations, connections and associations” (Pyyhtinen 2010, 25. Emphasis in original). As with Durkheim, as well as elements of Marx and Weber, associations come to the fore again. Society is something which is assembled out of connections.

This does not mean, however, that Simmel positions individuals at the core of his sociology. Unlike Weber, Simmel is not an individualist. For, he argues: “if we examine ‘individuals’ more closely, we realize that they are by no means such ultimate elements or ‘atoms’ of the human world. For the unit denoted by the concept ‘individual’ [...] is not an object of cognition at all, but only of experience” (Simmel 1950, 6). At this point, it is the individual who is put in inverted commas, rather than society. Neither individuals nor society can explain sociality or the social. Simmel has shifted focus away from the traditional concerns of sociology and prioritizes relations, connections and associations above either the individual or society. The social aspect inheres in connections between entities which themselves are not stable, fixed or given prior to the connections that they make.

The question that now arises is that of what constitutes such connections and how are we to understand them? Simmel’s answer is that sociology needs to approach such relations by considering them in terms of “dyads” and “triads” (Simmel 1950, 118–69). The notion of dyad indicates that, for Simmel, we should not start with individuals but with the relations between what we consider to be individuals. Remembering that the individual “is not an object of cognition at all, but only one of experience”, it becomes clear that while we might experience another person as an individual, this is something that we experience rather than something that we know. It is the reciprocal relation between two (human) entities which constitutes the individuals involved in that occasion. Simmel gives the example of a secret. There can be no such thing as an isolated secret. A secret is only a secret in so far as it is kept a secret from someone else. “General experience seems to indicate that this minimum of two, with which the secret ceases to be the property of one individual, is at the same time the maximum at which its preservation is relatively secure” (Simmel 1950, 123). This is not to suggest that the secret is the purest form of the dyadic relation; it is only an example, although a good one. What is vital is “this minimum of two”. If there are individuals, then they become “social” individuals because of this relation of two, this reciprocal relation to another. “The starting point of all social formations can only be the reciprocal effect between person to person” (Simmel, cited in Pyyhtinen 2010, 28). The triad introduces a third person, one who makes matters more complex, but the cornerstone of Simmel’s account remains the same. It is the reciprocal relations which come first. For Simmel, the social involves relations between (human) entities which become subjects or individuals within their dyadic and triadic relations.

Simmel then turns to the question of how sociology should study such relations and advocates what he calls “Formal Sociology”. This is, perhaps, an unfortunate phrase as it seems to be the opposite of “Informal Sociology”

(whatever that might be). In fact, what Simmel really wants to develop is a “Sociology of Forms”. Given that he sees neither individuals nor society, subjects or objects, as the base upon which a successful sociological analysis can be built, but instead views associations, reciprocal relations and connections as primary, then, Simmel argues, we need to analyse the forms that these relations take. That is the starting point of sociology: “if society is conceived as interaction among individuals, the description of the forms of this interaction is the task of the science of society in its strictest and most essential sense” (Simmel 1950, 21–22). As opposed to Durkheim who sees social facts as the basis of a scientific sociology, or Weber who views social action as key to a different kind of scientific sociology, for Simmel, it is the form that such interactions take which is key. This returns us to a common conceptual theme which runs throughout the works of Durkheim, Marx and Weber. It is the *manner*, the *mode*, the adverbial, which constitutes a vital aspect of the social. With Simmel it is *form* that takes on the role of expressing this idea: “form is the mutual determination and interaction of the elements of the association. It is form by means of which they create a unit” (Simmel 1950, 44). It is through the different *forms* of association, relation or connection that the elements involved become units. Only then can we validly talk of individuals or society, subjects or objects; once the process of formation has occurred. Hence, “one should properly speak, not of society, but of *sociation*. Society merely is the name for a number of individuals, connected by interaction” (Simmel 1950, 10. *Emphasis added*). For Simmel, the adverbial aspect is even more pronounced for, in an important sense, interaction *is* the social.

I am aware that I have just made a leap in the argument which is not, as yet, warranted, by identifying the social as “sociation”. This is a term and concept which requires further discussion. The original German term that Simmel uses and which is generally translated with “sociation” is “*Vergesellschaftung*”; indeed this word is included in the title of one of his major works: “Sociology: Studies on the Forms of Sociation” (*Soziologie: Untersuchungen über die Formen der Vergesellschaftung* – Simmel 1908). As mentioned in Chapter Five, “*Vergesellschaftung*” is a term which Simmel coined himself and was later adopted by Weber. It is a noun which incorporates the notion of movement and process and, thus, is eminently suited to Simmel’s concern to formulate his approach to sociology as one which prioritizes connections, relations, dyads and triads, rather than any substantial notions of the individual or society. Wolff (1950, lxiii) notes that this word has been “mistranslated” to “socialization” in some editions. This would seem correct as this is a loaded term, especially since the time of Parsons, and it seems to presuppose the existence of discrete individuals who need to be socialized into a given society. However, Wolff’s choice of “sociation” is not without its own problems.

It has the benefit of being a neologism but it runs the risk of erasing the difference between the social and the societal; the distinction between “*sozial*” and “*gesellschaftlich*” (as discussed in Chapter Four). Indeed, Pyyhtinen (2010) translates “*Vergesellschaftung*” as “societalization”. Having said this, I am not sure that this is as serious a matter as it is with either Marx or Weber, as the main aim of Simmel’s approach is to develop a novel concept of how sociality operates. In this vein he states: “it is *sociation* which synthesizes all human interest, contents, and processes into concrete units” (Simmel 1950, 4. Emphasis in original). Sociation (“*Vergesellschaftung*”) is a principle which is not reliant upon human individuals but through which the processes in which humans find themselves are synthesized and become units, such as the individual. Once again, the individual is an outcome, not a starting point for both life and sociology. The same applies to societies.

[T]he interactions we have in mind when we talk about “society” are crystallized as definable, consistent structures such as the state and the family, guild and the church, social classes and organizations based on common interests. But in addition to these, there exists an immeasurable number of less conspicuous forms of relationship and kinds of interaction. (Simmel 1950, 9)

What we think of as societies are outcomes: they are crystallizations of the same processes by which individuals come to be. One mistake that sociology has made is in positing society as the generator of the social rather than seeing the social (“*Vergesellschaftung*”) as the vehicle by which societies take on an apparently concrete form. A second mistake that sociology makes, according to Simmel, is to ignore the numerous and widespread occasions of other forms of sociality; those which are comported by “minor” reciprocal relations of a dyadic or triadic form (such as the keeping of a secret). A third mistake that sociology has made is in concentrating on the notion of the supposedly collective whole of a society, whilst ignoring the importance of groups. In this respect, Simmel sides with Weber against Durkheim.

In order to understand how the social operates, according to Simmel, we also need to look at the role of sociation in group formation. Indeed, Simmel almost defines sociation as “the life of groups as units” (Simmel 1950, 26). And, it should be noted that his major discussion of dyads and triads comes under the long section with the heading, “Quantitative Aspects of the Group” (Simmel 1950, 87–177; 1908, 32–100) and not of society. He sets out his position as follows: “Sociology asks what happens to men [*sic*] and by what rules they behave, not insofar as they unfold their understandable individual existences in their totalities, but insofar as they form groups and are determined by their group existence because of interaction” (Simmel 1950, 11). It is group

formation which is key, not the individual and certainly not society. Again, this approach has similarities to Weber who also focusses on groups and group formation, rather than on any notion of a substantive society.

Overall, Simmel provides a robust and refreshing challenge to certain preconceptions of the social, such as those of the place of the individual and society, as well as the importance of process, connections and relations. However, as set out in Chapter One, his work was not focussed on in this book as his influence has not been as great as that of Durkheim, Marx and Weber. Though his ideas tend toward the philosophical and are suggestive as to what a “philosophy of the social” might entail, Simmel does not set out a coherent philosophical approach to the problems of the social. The next, final, chapter will be able to develop such a philosophy which draws on, yet moves beyond, the innovative and competing conceptions of the social developed in classical sociology and forgotten in the course of the twentieth century.

Conclusion

What is clear from the summaries of the writings of Durkheim, Marx and Weber (and Simmel) is that the problem of the social is not as simple as might first be thought. One important conclusion which can be drawn is that it would be dangerous to reject “traditional” concepts of the social, as writers such as Latour (1993, 2005) seem to advocate. The social constituted a problem for Durkheim, Marx and Weber in different ways and each responded to this problem with some genuine critical insights. There is still much we could take from their work. More importantly, we should realize that none of these writers viewed the social as something self-explanatory or as easily understood. They all engaged in on-going debates, which they returned to and reoriented throughout their texts. It was only really Weber who came to a final position, one which brings its own strictures.

As I have argued throughout this book, the contest over what constitutes the social was an integral part of the defining moments of sociology and social theory. This contest was never won, it was simply sidelined and forgotten. The earlier discussions of Durkheim, Marx and Weber were intended to help restart debate and to outline the problems and possible contributions that these writers identified. But, in order to re-engage with the heart of the problem of the social and to clear away some of the unwarranted assumptions and presumptions which underlie the easy usage of the term “social”, I believe it is necessary to return to the social as a problem and, indeed, to develop a philosophy of the social. This will be the topic of the following, final, chapter.

